



Ayan Acharya

ayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

When Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) signed Mayank Yadav in the 2022 IPL auction for his base price of ₹20 lakh, their fans would have been forgiven for asking — “Who?” No one could claim to have much knowledge of the 21-year-old. The Delhi pacer had not been unearthed by a scouting database nor had he been talked up by informed commentators.

In old-school, word-of-mouth fashion, Mayank had been recommended to LSG by the franchise’s assistant coach and talent scout, Vijay Dahiya, who had spotted the bowler in the nets during the Vijay Hazare Trophy in 2021. Unpredictability makes for a special kind of viewing in sports. When would he play? What could he offer?

At the time of going to press, Mayank’s bowling profile on the official LSG website remains unchanged, still labelled as right-arm

medium-fast. Yet the cricketing landscape tells a different tale. With repeated bursts touching speeds well over 150 kilometres per hour (kmph) — including one that clocked 156.7 kmph against Royal Challengers Bengaluru — Mayank has seasoned international batters dancing to his tune.

Such prowess has ignited whispers of his selection for the T20 World Cup, set to be played in the USA and the West Indies in June. T.A. Sekar, a former India quick and fast bowling coach, feels it is best to strike while the iron is hot. “If he performs well in the remaining IPL matches, rattling the best in the business, there is no reason why he shouldn’t be considered for higher honours,” Sekar told *Sportstar*.

Former West Indian pacer Ian Bishop has called Mayank ‘the child of the wind’ on X after the latter ran through RCB’s batting line-up with a spell of 4-0-14-3. “Nothing else needs to be seen to add a sixth name to the fast-bowling contracts list,” Bishop wrote on social media, referring to the fast-bowling contracts handed

Variation is key: During this IPL, LSG captain KL Rahul (right) has not used Mayank in the final overs yet. Working on an effective slower ball might help him if he is summoned between overs 17 and 20. K. MURALIKUMAR

out by the national selection committee. The five bowlers currently on the list are Akash Deep, who made his debut in the fourth Test against England in Ranchi, Vijaykumar Vyshak, Umran Malik, Yash Dayal and V. Kaverappa.

Former national selector Jatin Paranjpe thinks that adding Mayank to the above list would be a prudent first step. “In fact, it wouldn’t be surprising if five or six names were added to the list after this IPL to create a pool of bowlers who are managed slightly differently. If Mayank does well consistently, his name should be in it,” Paranjpe said.

The raw pace and the ability to hustle batsmen with the short ball make Mayank a key component of the LSG attack. But to make the step up and be in World Cup contention,